

Chapter 104-1 - Spider Lily

The daylight had already darkened, the moon hanging halfway in the sky. The rosy clouds were gone, a few early-bright stars twinkled drowsily, and the distant river water trickled softly.

Ning Fuyi stood outside the stuffy door in a daze. Her hands still bore traces of Su Mo's blood, now dried in the dry summer night.

The medicinal scent occasionally wafted through the cracks of the small house, the trembling lamplight turning into golden liquid, flowing through the gaps.

Ning Fuyi seemed to be pondering something, but actually wasn't thinking of anything. She just stood there emptying her mind, her head feeling as if it had been filled with wax, murky and somewhat swollen with pain.

Not knowing how long had passed - long enough for her standing feet to feel numb - the door finally creaked open. Jiang Li appeared at the doorway with a grave expression, looking tired and holding several silver needles in her hand.

"Come in." She stepped aside.

Ning Fuyi stepped forward, but suddenly it was as if her legs had disappeared. Her body swayed, and Xique beside her quickly supported her, sighing: "Master.."

Ning Fuyi shook her head to indicate she was fine, then stamped her feet. When the numbness lessened, she slowly entered the lamplight.

The bloody smell in the room had been suppressed by herbs. Now it was quiet and peaceful, showing no signs of the earlier panic. Su Mo lay on the bed, her face pale, chest rising and falling. Looking closely, even the skull flower¹ on her face seemed much fainter.

Seeing Ning Fuyi enter, she smiled weakly and then stretched out her arms toward her.

Ning Fuyi quickly walked a few steps and leaned down into her arms. Su Mo naturally circled her arms around her, placing her warm palms on her back and patting gently.

"Su Mo, fine." Su Mo said haltingly.

"Being fine is good, being fine is good. You scared me to death." Ning Fuyi's nasal cavity stung as she buried her face against Su Mo's neck.

Jiang Li didn't disturb them, quietly organizing medicine bottles on the side, pretending not to see.

When the sourness faded, Ning Fuyi finally sat up, took Su Mo's hand and held it, saying to Jiang Li: "How is she?"

Jiang Li was about to go out to speak when Su Mo tightened her palm, her reddened peach blossom eyes looking at Ning Fuyi.

"Just speak here." Ning Fuyi smiled at Jiang Li. "I apologize for the trouble."

Jiang Li's gaze swept over Su Mo, speaking with regret: "I can't find any illness in her, no wounds or poisoning either. It's just that overnight, her heart and lungs have withered."

"Like an oil lamp about to burn out - when the oil runs dry, the lamp dies."

Ning Fuyi wasn't surprised by this assessment; she found it quite reasonable. She nodded: "How much time does she have left?"

"Perhaps by the end of this year, perhaps by next spring." Jiang Li turned the medicine bottle in her fingertips, raising her hand to give it to her. "This can prevent her from suffering too much from the deterioration before she dies."

Ning Fuyi took it and thanked her.

"I won't stay longer then. You two should talk more." Jiang Li smiled warmly, stepped out of the room, and closed the door tightly for them.

Only the breathing of two people remained in the room. Ning Fuyi gently lifted her dress hem and sat on the edge of the bed. Su Mo slowly sat up to face her closely.

Just as Ning Fuyi was about to speak, she suddenly felt a pain in her ear. She drew in a breath and laughed.

Su Mo's teeth were still resting on Ning Fuyi's round earlobe. She bit down a bit more but couldn't bear to bite harder, so she released it.

Ning Fuyi pulled her up from her embrace, pinched the back of her neck and mouthed: "Why did you bite me?"

"I want, to make you, remember me." Su Mo was very close to her, her eyes examining left and right as if she could never see enough.

So she held Ning Fuyi's face with both hands and rubbed it forcefully. Ning Fuyi's mouth shifted with the movement, not knowing whether to cry or laugh.

"How could I forget?" Ning Fuyi also wanted to bite back, but as she leaned down, the woman in her arms slipped away like a fish.

"If I die, will she, be able to come back?" Su Mo's voice became heavier, her nose tip turning red.

Ning Fuyi was somewhat stunned, suddenly feeling guilty like a child who knew she had done something wrong. She clutched her clothing tightly and didn't speak for a long while.

Finally, she nodded.

Su Mo smiled faintly: "Then that's good."

"What's good about it?" Ning Fuyi sighed in defeat.

"Then when I die, she will, come back. You, won't be sad." Su Mo combined speaking with gesturing.

Ning Fuyi's tears almost burst forth. She pressed them back by biting her tongue hard, turning her face to one side and shaking her head repeatedly.

"You have blood on you. Let me wipe it off for you."

Ning Fuyi got up and went outside, using the time to boil water to let the wind clear her head before bringing in a basin.

The bloodstains were mainly on her neck. Ning Fuyi carefully wiped away all the filth, then turned back: "Your clothes are dirty too. I'll get new ones."

Ning Fuyi rummaged through boxes to find clean new clothes. These were ones Ning Fuyi had secretly bought with earned silver a few days ago, the best fabric she could find in town. Under the lamplight, they looked like rippling blue waves under a clear sky.

She returned to the bedside, reached out to untie the clothing belt around Su Mo's waist, removed her currently soiled clothes, and put on the new ones.

Su Mo was embarrassed but didn't stop her, so after tying the belt, both their gazes became somewhat evasive.

"Your foot clothing is also dirty." Ning Fuyi spoke, reaching out to touch it, but Su Mo shrank back her feet as if startled. Because she retreated so quickly, the back of her head knocked against the bed post with a thud.

Ning Fuyi was immediately surprised. She looked up questioningly, only to see Su Mo's face full of blush, stammering.

"Not, not good-looking." She covered her toes with bedding.

"How could they not be good-looking? Everything about you is beautiful." Ning Fuyi blurted out, making Su Mo's face even redder.

"Really, not, not good-looking." Su Mo was very conflicted, but finally couldn't resist Ning Fuyi. She closed her eyes and removed her foot coverings, not daring to look.

Ning Fuyi had thought it was just some old injury and she could say a few comforting words. But when she saw the hideous scars covering everything below the calves, a sharp ringing immediately filled her mind.

Seeing her expression, Su Mo thought she had really frightened her, so she quickly shrank into the bedding, stuttering: "I, I, I told you, not, not good-looking..."

But Ning Fuyi was quick to grab her ankle and pull it out from under the bedding, also pulling Su Mo's entire body toward herself, causing Su Mo to cry out softly.

Ning Fuyi's expression was too dark, frightening Su Mo. She cowered while hugging the bedding:
"Yi, Yiji..."

"When did you get these injuries?" Ning Fuyi spoke, her fingertips touching those scars that looked as if they had been carved by knives over and over again. Each time she touched, Su Mo trembled.

"Born, with them." Su Mo grabbed Ning Fuyi's sleeve, saying timidly: "Are you, scared?"

Only then did Ning Fuyi realize something. She loosened her tight grip on her ankle, sat sideways beside her, embraced her in her arms, and carefully comforted her.

"I'm not afraid, just, surprised." Ning Fuyi said, heartache spilling from the corners of her eyes. She still stared at those scars, always feeling their shape was familiar.

Did Chu Qingqiu have such wounds? She remembered not seeing any. When she had seen her barefoot at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, there had been nothing unusual.

But with Chu Qingqiu's divine powers, concealing scars would be effortless.

These things were definitely scars, absolutely not birthmarks. But what kind of scars could attach to the soul and still exist through incarnations?

Suddenly, an image flashed before Ning Fuyi's eyes: a wound deep to the bone on a pale hand. She quickly pulled over Su Mo's right hand, examining it against the lamplight.

A shallow scar appeared, not as gruesome as those on her legs and feet, but still quite obvious.

It was just that because Su Mo's hands were already crisscrossed with scars, Ning Fuyi had never paid attention before.

She knew! Ning Fuyi looked up with deep confusion.

It was the spider lily².

Footnotes:

1. **Skull flower (骷髏花)** - A specific flower mentioned earlier in the story that appears as a birthmark on Su Mo's face, likely referring to her distinctive facial marking.
2. **Spider lily (彼岸花)** - In East Asian folklore, spider lilies (*Lycoris radiata*) are associated with death, reincarnation, and the underworld. They are said to bloom along the path to the afterlife and are often called "flowers of the other shore" or "hell flowers." The recognition of this pattern suggests a connection to Su Mo's past life and the supernatural elements of her condition.